



07 – Video Production Plan

*Production exists to serve three goals, in order: (1) **ship daily, reliably** — consistency drives the watch-time and subscribers that unlock monetization; (2) **sound and look credible** — never let quality undercut Blow's authority; (3) **scale production value as revenue allows**. Start lean and deliberate; reinvest into the team and kit as milestones hit (see 06).*

Production requirements by segment

☀️ Lunch Break Live – 10 min, LIVE, daily

The constraint is **reliability and speed**, not polish. It must go live the same time every day without fail.

- **Live-stream pipeline:** stream directly to YouTube (and simulcast to other platforms) via **OBS Studio** (free) or **Streamyard/Restream** (cloud, simplest, multi-platform out of the box).
- **Single-camera, locked framing** — Blow at desk, no switching needed.
- **On-screen elements:** lower-third name/title, episode title, live-chat callout, "subscribe" bug, animated open (3–5 sec) + close.
- **Backup plan:** a phone hotspot + a pre-recorded "evergreen" fallback in case the stream drops. Live = things break; plan for it.
- **Latency-tolerant:** comments scrolling on a second monitor so Blow can react live.

🌙 The Evening Show – 20 min, guest conversation, daily

The constraint is **clean conversation capture + clip-ability**, including remote guests.

- **Recorded, not live** (usually) → room to fix, chapter, and polish.
- **Remote-guest capture:** **Riverside.fm** or **Descript Rooms** — record each participant locally in HD/separate tracks (not Zoom compression). This is the single most important tool for guest quality.
- **In-studio guests:** two-camera setup (host + guest) or a single wide + two tights.
- **Multi-track audio** so each voice is editable and clip-ready independently.
- **B-roll / graphics** capacity for "The Throughline" and "The Receipts" beats.

The kit (lean Phase 1 → scaled later)

Phase 1 – "Start lean and deliberate" (one-person-operable)

Prioritize **audio first** — viewers forgive mediocre video, not bad audio.

NEED	LEAN CHOICE	NOTES
Camera	Quality webcam (Logitech Brio 4K) or a mirrorless/DSLR as webcam	One camera is enough to start
Audio 🌟	Broadcast dynamic mic (Shure MV7 / SM7B + interface)	The #1 credibility lever
Lighting	1–2 key lights + softbox (Elgato Key Light / Aputure)	Consistent, flattering, repeatable
Backdrop/set	Simple branded set corner: bookshelf, plant, signage, controlled color	Recognizable in any thumbnail
Live software	OBS or Streamyard	Lunch Break Live pipeline
Remote guests	Riverside.fm	Evening Show guest capture
Edit/clips	Descript + CapCut/Premiere	Descript's text-based editing = fast turnaround
Teleprompter	iPad + prompter app (optional)	For tight Live opens
Connectivity	Hardwired ethernet + backup hotspot	Live demands reliability

Phase 2–3 – "Raise production value" (as revenue funds the team)

- Dedicated **studio** or upgraded home studio; multi-camera switching (ATEM Mini).
- **Camera operator / live producer** running the switcher and chat.
- Cinema/mirrorless cameras, professional lighting grid, acoustic treatment.
- Motion-graphics package (animated lower-thirds, segment stings, data viz for "The Receipts").
- On-site capability for marquee guests; remote field kits.
- Color grading + audio mastering pass on the Evening Show.

Reinvestment rule: every production upgrade should trace to a milestone hit. Don't buy the studio before the subscribers justify it (06).

Daily run-of-show (operational checklist)

- MORNING
 - Story selection + Blow's notes for Lunch Break Live
 - Tech check: stream, audio levels, lighting, connection, backup ready
- MIDDAY
 - ☀️ GO LIVE — Lunch Break Live (10 min) + monitor chat
 - Editor starts pulling Live clips immediately
- AFTERNOON
 - Record 🌙 Evening Show (guest) OR pull from banked reserve
 - Cut + caption Live clips; schedule
 - Draft Daily Read note from the Live take
- EVENING
 - Publish Evening Show + queue its clips
 - Community thread, Quote of the Day, next-day guest teaser
- WEEKLY
 - Column + newsletter (Fri) · Mailbag · best-of reel · bank a reserve episode

Production roles (lean core → scale)

ROLE	PHASE	RESPONSIBILITY
Host / EP (Charles Blow)	All	On-camera, editorial voice, columns
Producer / showrunner	P1	Run-of-show, booking, live direction, calendar
Editor (clips + episodes) ⭐	P1	The clip pipeline + Evening Show polish — earliest hire
Live producer / switcher op	P2	Runs the stream, chat, multi-cam (offloads the host)
Social/community manager	P1–P2	Scheduling, engagement, Stories
Motion designer (contract)	P2	Graphics package, segment stings, data viz

First two hires that matter most: a **producer** (so the show ships daily without Blow doing logistics) and an **editor** (so the clip engine runs). Everything else can come as revenue allows.

Production-quality milestones (mapped to the path to success)

SUCCESS MILESTONE (06)	PRODUCTION MOVE IT FUNDS
1. Reach monetization (10k YT subs)	Validate the lean kit + daily reliability; nail the clip pipeline
2. Grow the audience	Add live producer + second camera; upgrade audio/lighting; richer graphics
3. Reach profitability	Dedicated studio, multi-cam, motion-graphics package, on-site marquee shoots

The production north star: *never miss a day, never let audio embarrass us, and reinvest every revenue gain into making the show look and sound a little bigger than the audience expects.*